

ing to the United States. As a student, Vinod could get an additional twenty dollars for books after approval of the Reserve Bank of India. He remembers waiting at Reserve Bank's Parliament Street office in New Delhi for two days without any fruitful outcome.

Then his elder brother, the banker, offered support for arranging that money. However, Vinod refused that help after knowing that his brother had to approach the approving officer. He says, "I was offended that I needed his help to get a simple job done, that I was quite entitled to. But India those days was more about whom you knew and not what you knew."

"So, I actually reached America only with just eight dollars in my pocket. After reaching there, I went to the foreign students' office. There was a student counselor who had been corresponding with me for a year. She asked what she could do for me. I asked about my research assistant job. That was supposed to get me 325 dollars. She said I wouldn't get that money until I did a month's work. I told her I needed at least 75 dollars for rent and 15 dollars for health insurance, even though I needed some more money for food. She went to a room and came back with 125 dollars in cash. It was a distress fund. Later, I paid it back at zero percent interest at about 25 dollars a month, after getting my salary.

"My first salary in the USA was USD325," Vinod recalls. "Fortunately, within nine months of being there, the dean offered me a temporary teaching position to teach in the semiconductor lab, since the professor responsible for teaching in that lab was on a year-long sabbatical. Since I was the only student who had a semiconductor background and understood how chips are made, packaged, and tested, and the entire gamut of things, I was offered the job. Initially, I was quite reluctant to accept it as I had never taught before and was not confident that I could really stand in front of people and teach. However, my advisor encouraged me and I accepted. I very much



Intel CEO Andy Grove with the Pentium Team key contributors
lead by Vinod Dham

enjoyed my teaching assignment and the perks that came with it. I also felt like a king as my salary was raised to 625 dollars, the biggest jump I ever had," he says.

Vinod believes in learning by doing. He followed the same principle in his teaching as well. The university compiled a book based on his lectures. "I got to know about that book from the students who joined Intel after graduating from that school. They used to tell me that they had studied my book. I was surprised as I'd never written a book; I'd only compiled my lectures. It turns out the school had taken those and made a book out of them, and they were charging them 20 or 25 dollars. After finding this out, I called my professor and jokingly said that they had not paid me royalty for my book. He just laughed off. They were wonderful people," he says with a smile.

Vinod enjoyed his study days in the USA thoroughly. "I think education in America is an absolutely enjoyable experience. Especially for the Indians, it is a piece of cake. That's why all the Indians who come here just fly high," he opines. In India, I felt the professors were finding reasons to filter you out; here they were genuinely trying to help you learn. He completed his

master's degree with ease.

However, even before completing the same, he got a chance to experience the "true American way of life," as he describes, through an invitation from one of his fellow students. "It was the first American house that I ever went to. I was blown away because I had always been staying in an apartment, sharing

a small room with another student. But this fellow who invited me had a proper house with many bedrooms, full of music and fun." That experience allured him to taste such a life.

"I remember going back to my advisor and telling him that I would prefer not to do a PhD. He got very upset with my decision because he had gotten some grants from NASA for my research work. I decided to continue research as per his wish as I knew that I wouldn't get letter of recommendation for a job from him, if I offend him. There was no concept of an H1-B visa then. Your professor had to write a letter of recommendation for you to go to a company to get practical training. So, I went back and started working on the PhD again. But my advisor came back to me even before I finished my work. He asked me to go for interview with NCR Microelectronics, which was a big sponsor of his semiconductor lab. NCR had reached out to him for a trained resource to solve some issues in their important project and, again, my name showed up at the top because I was the only student with work experience in semiconductors. He promised me that even if I did not get selected, he would let me go after my master's degree. Since I didn't have a car, he drove me for the interview. Fortunately, I got selected and